Newsletter: September 2025

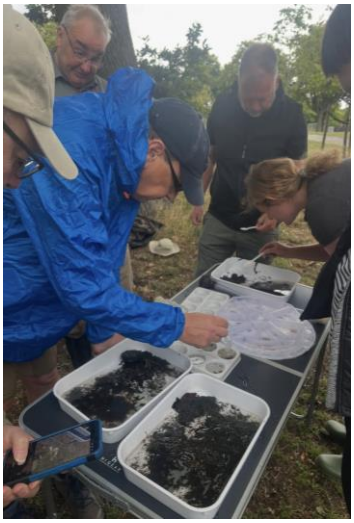
Overview:

Hello River Champions! This newsletter provides updates on recent training and groups that have signed up. We will also take a 'deep dive' into **your** results taken so far.

Training Days and New Recruits:

We would like to warmly welcome the Friends of Bradford Street, who attended training on water chemistry sampling earlier in the summer. They will monitor the Rea in Digbeth before it flows underground.

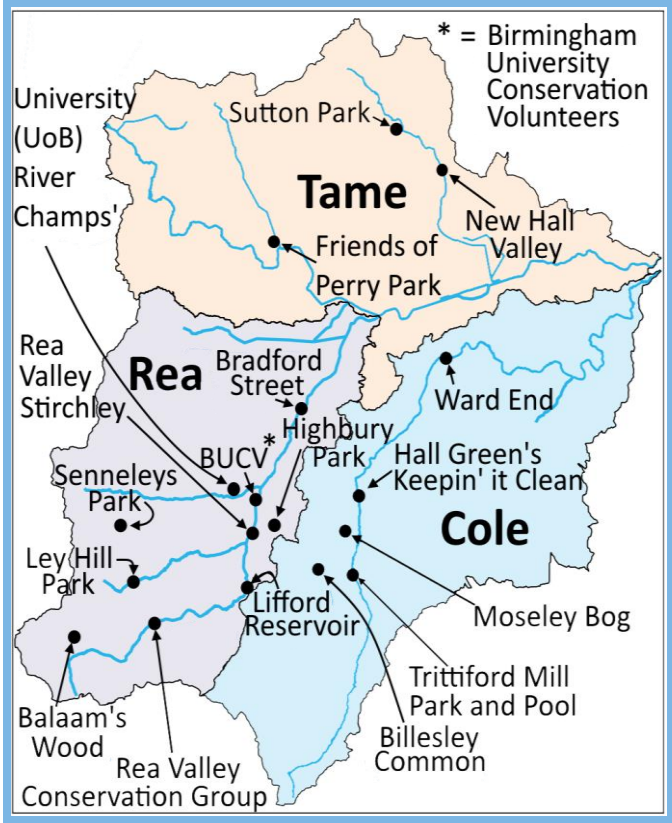
On 5th August, Asha Gurung (University of Birmingham) and Richard Orton (Friends of Sutton Park) led training for the Friends of New Valley. We later joined the group for their first session where they received their official Urban Riverfly certification.





Group overview:

We now have **18** groups and **133** volunteers within the project - and we would like to extend our gratitude to everyone involved!



Sampling overview:

Overleaf we present results on your data, where in total you have collected:

- **167** Urban River samples – this is more than the Environment Agency have collected in the last **15 years!**
- **112** water chemistry samples.

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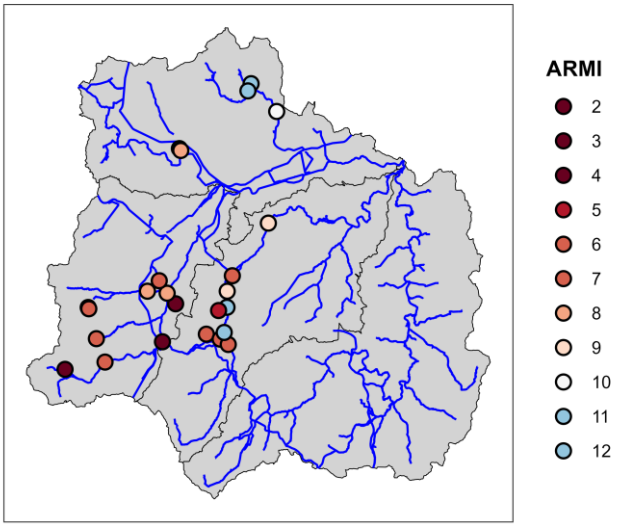
Results:

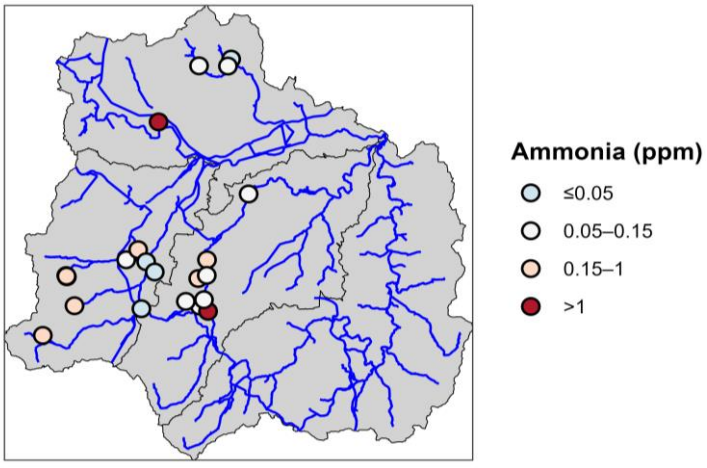
We would like to give a special mention to those that have made our sampling leaderboard for their dedication! The Friends of Trittiford and Sutton Park in particular have been outstanding, sampling multiple sites consistently for a long time now – so a huge thanks for your efforts!

Group	No. samples
Friends of Trittiford Mill Pool and Park	32
Friends of Sutton Park	30
Friends of Moseley Bog and Joy's Wood	15
Friends of Billesley Common	13
UoB River Champions	12
Friends of Senneleys Park	8
Friends of Leyhill Park	6
Rea Valley Conservation Group	6

Urban Riverfly:

Our best estimate shows a whopping **26838** invertebrates have been counted. Relative to national surveys, over **33%** of samples showed **lower** ecological health (ARMI ≤ 6), while only **5%** reached the **higher** end (ARMI ≥ 14). Aside from the 'red flags', Sutton Park displayed healthier scores. But we also found pollution-sensitive species at sites like the Cole (Dingles – flat-bodied mayfly) and Bartley Brook (Senneleys – stonefly) — a hopeful sign!





Ammonia:

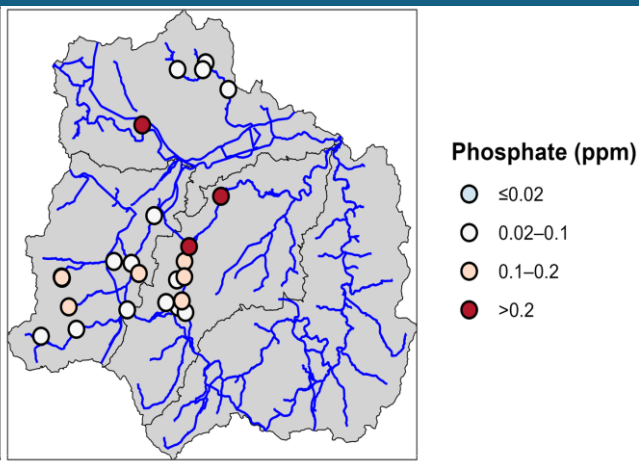
Ammonia helps detect sewage pollution, but fewer samples (73) were collected due to equipment issues. Yet, 'hotspots' like the Holbrook, Rea headwaters and parts of the Cole stood out. 15% of our samples surpassed the national standard (0.25ppm).

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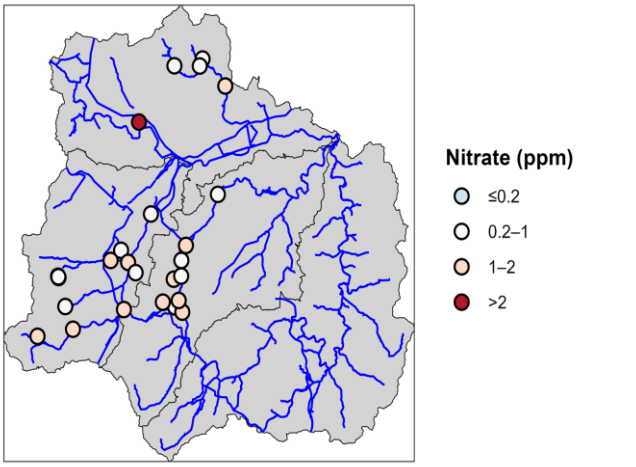
Phosphate:

A type of ‘macronutrient’ that plants and algae need to grow, but can become excessive with detergent and wastewater inputs. **38%** of our samples exceeded national environmental standards (0.1 ppm), with higher pollution being found along the lower stretches of the Cole and the Holbrook.



Nitrate

Another form of ‘macronutrient’ often more directly associated with sewage (it is related to ammonia). You can see a different picture here where **67%** of our samples were more polluted than national standards. Higher values were observed across various locations, but again were particularly high in Holbrook.



Rugby River Champions:

Based on the work that we have achieved within this project, Rugby Borough Council will soon be funding us to take our work to their patch. We will use the Birmingham River Champions as a blueprint, where will look to collect river health data and communicate results to volunteers *via* an online interactive platform .

Thank you for reading our latest updates, a few reminders:

- Groups can upload their surveys via our **online survey form**.
- Please check out **our website** to see results that **you** have collected.
- Please contact us if you would like **more support**, project partners are keen to help support data collection and help make in impact.

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